

John Root, was on completion the world's largest office block. It was also one of the earliest examples of what would become the signature of downtown urban America: the skyscraper. It is constructed almost exclusively in dark, almost purple bricks. The designers deliberately avoided any form of decoration beyond the bay windows that surge upward, almost like half-columns, to give the building a sort of undulating elegance. Although modern in style, structurally it looked backward, being supported by masonry rather than constructed around an iron frame. Its 6-ft- (2-m-) thick ground-floor walls would not have been out of place in a medieval castle.

Wainwright Building

Location St. Louis, Missouri

Completed in 1891, the Wainwright Building was an example of a new sort of immense urban architecture. It also looked back to the past: the building, faced with vivid terracotta, was conceived by its designers Dankmar Adler and Louis Sullivan as a sort of huge Classical column

with base, shaft, and capital. It does feature decorative elements, notably the elaborate panels under the windows and the mass of curling foliage under its boldly projecting cornice. However, it also looked decisively ahead. Not only was it built around a steel core, but it was intended to create and house a series of identical cells that were functional; efficient; and, above all, modern.

Pennsylvania Station

Location New York, New York

Pennsylvania Station—completed in 1910 to the designs of the firm of McKim, Mead, and White—was a late example of Classical architecture in the modern world, partly influenced by Rome and partly by Beaux Arts Paris. Intended to stun and amaze, it had a vast multicolumned facade, accented at each end by templelike pediments, that gave way to an immense central concourse and deliberately echoed the marbled public glories of ancient Rome. Beyond them was a series of platforms lit by large windows. A belief that the site could be used more profitably saw the building controversially demolished 50 years later.

Woolworth Building

Location New York, New York

The Woolworth Building is arguably the most magnificent pre-World War I building in the US. A Neo-Gothic skyscraper, it consists of an immense 29-story base from which surges an even taller 30-story central tower, topped by huge pinnacles and lanterns. It was completed in 1913, and at 792 ft (241 m) high, it was the world's tallest building until 1930. It also boasted the most complex elevator system yet built. Its architect was the prolific Cass Gilbert. Its presiding genius was F. W. Woolworth, a man intent on creating a building that would celebrate his commercial supremacy.



▲ THE CENTRAL TOWER OF THE WOOLWORTH BUILDING RISING ABOVE THE LOWER TOWERS

